



FEBRUARY 25TH 2026

WRONGFUL DISCHARGE AND LABOR PROTECTIONS SPECIAL COMMITTEE AGENDA

Date: Wednesday February 25, 2026
Time: 6:00 PM
Location: City Hall Council Chambers 108 East Green Street, 3rd Fl Ithaca, NY 14850
Watch Online: <https://www.youtube.com/@CityofIthacaPublicMeetings>

1. Call To Order

- 1.a. Emergency Evacuation Notice
- 1.b. Agenda Review

2. Petitions and Hearings of Persons Before Council

- 2.a. Statements From The Public (30 Minutes)

3. Order of Business

- 3.a. Review of Committee Charge (45 Minutes)
- 3.b. Discussion of Scope and Scale of Wrongful Discharge and Labor Protection Issues and Data Collection Plan (45 Minutes)

Resolution Establishing a Special Committee through 2026 on Wrongful Discharge and Labor Protections

WHEREAS, at the 2024 Common Council Legislative Retreat, worker protections and “Just Cause” legislation were identified as a high-impact, high-feasibility policy priority for the City of Ithaca; and

WHEREAS, on March 20, 2025, the Common Council voted to include Just Cause labor protections among its adopted legislative priorities; and

WHEREAS, the Mayor previously established the Wrongful Discharge and Labor Protections Working Group, which conducted preliminary review and submitted a memorandum dated August 28, 2025, outlining findings and recommending additional community engagement, legal analysis, and a phased legislative approach in connection with the topic of wrongful discharge and labor protections; and

WHEREAS, the Working Group, as reauthorized on August 28, 2025, did not thereafter convene or complete the work contemplated by its reauthorization; and

WHEREAS, the Mayor and Common Council find that continued work on wrongful discharge and labor protections warrants elevation to a Special Committee to ensure transparency, accountability, continuity, and structured coordination with staff and the public; and

WHEREAS, the Mayor and Common Council recognize that worker protections are essential to advancing equity, economic stability, and community well-being, and that durable legislation requires a clear factual record, inclusive public process, and careful legal and fiscal analyses;

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT RESOLVED, that the Mayor and Common Council hereby establish a Special Committee on Wrongful Discharge and Labor Protections, effective upon adoption of this resolution, to operate through December 31, 2026; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the purpose of the Special Committee shall be to evaluate, develop, and advance as appropriate potential legislation related to wrongful discharge and labor protections, consistent with the Common Council’s adopted legislative priorities and prior guidance; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the Special Committee shall consist of five (5) members of the Common Council; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the Special Committee shall ascertain the scope and scale of wrongful discharge and labor protection issues within the City of Ithaca through public testimony and stakeholder engagement, including workers, labor organizations, unions, employers, business associations, and community stakeholders, including, but not limited to, the Tompkins County Workers’ Center, the Cornell University School of Industrial and Labor Relations, the Downtown Ithaca Alliance, the Tompkins County Chamber of Commerce, and Ithaca Area Economic Development; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the City Manager shall direct the City Attorney to provide, within ninety (90) days of the effective date of this resolution, an assessment of the legal feasibility, administrative requirements, fiscal implications, and risk of state or federal preemption associated with prospective legislation, and to provide such analysis to the Special Committee and the Common Council; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the Special Committee shall meet monthly at 6:00 PM on the fourth Wednesday of each month, with additional meetings scheduled as necessary, shall be fully compliant with Open Meetings Law, and shall have at least 30 minutes set aside for public comment at each meeting; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the City Manager shall designate an appropriate staff member to assist with public meetings, any necessary publications, and solicitation of comment, input, and expert advice; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that no later than one hundred eighty (180) days after the effective date of this resolution, the Special Committee shall develop and adopt a statement of principles and policy objectives clarifying the scope, legislative intent, policy rationale, covered populations, enforcement framework, economic impact, and implementation considerations of any proposed legislation, and shall submit such statement to the Mayor, City Manager, City Clerk, and City Attorney; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that, upon a finding of the legality of implementation of wrongful discharge and labor protection legislation, the City Attorney's Office shall provide draft legislative language for consideration by the Common Council within ninety (90) days of receipt of the adopted principles and policy objectives approved by a vote of the Special Committee, or return a report identifying issues that prevent the drafting of legislation that is in conformance with the adopted principles and policy objectives; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that upon receipt of draft legislative language, the Special Committee shall conduct no fewer than three (3) well-publicized public forums prior to submission of a complete report and shall review any proposed legislation to ensure consistency with its adopted principles and policy objectives; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the Special Committee shall adopt a final report including draft legislative language approved by the Committee and a fiscal impact statement addressing anticipated impacts on the City's budget; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the City Manager shall direct the City Controller to furnish all information reasonably necessary to support the fiscal impact statement and shall review the statement prior to finalization and may include, as appropriate, a written narrative reflecting the Finance Department's findings; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the final report shall be adopted by the Special Committee and referred to the Committee of the Whole of the Common Council for consideration; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the Chair of the Special Committee shall meet from time to time with the Mayor to discuss progress and shall, upon request, provide written and oral reports to

the Common Council with no fewer than seven (7) days' notice, but shall provide at least one interim written update to the Common Council prior to submission of its final report; and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that the City Manager shall assign appropriate staff to provide administrative support to the meetings, agenda preparation, staffing, and other supporting work for the Special Committee; and

BE IT FINALLY RESOLVED, that the Special Committee shall be dissolved immediately upon submission of its final report to the Committee of the Whole of the Common Council, or on December 31, 2026, whichever occurs first.

Carried 9-1,
(Fabrizio-Opposed)
(Kirby-Absent)